

HERE AND THERE

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HERE AND THERE

COPERNICUS

A DIALOGUE^[1]

By GIACOMO LEOPARDI

Scene I: The First Hour and the Sun

First Hour. [2] Good morning, Excellency.

The Sun. Yes. Actually, good night.

First Hour. Your horses are ready.

The Sun. Indeed.

First Hour. Diana [3] came forth quite a while ago.

The Sun. Indeed. Let her come and go as she pleases.

First Hour. What does Your Excellency mean?

The Sun. I mean stop bothering me.

First Hour. But Excellency, the night has already lasted longer than it ought. And if we delay—look, Excellency, some disorders may arise.

The Sun. Let them arise. I'm not moving.

First Hour. Oh, Excellency, what's the matter? Would You feel ill?

The Sun. No, no. I don't feel anything except that I don't want to move. And therefore, you, get out, and mind your own business.

First Hour. But how can I leave if You don't come? I'm the day's First Hour, and how can there be any day unless Your Excellency condescends, as is his custom, to come forth?

The Sun. If you won't be the day's, you'll be the night's; or the night's hours will do double-duty, and you and your companions can take a rest. For—you know what?—I'm tired of this continual going around to make light for a few animalcules that live on a handful of mud too small for me, who have good vision, to see. And this night I have determined to use no more toil for this purpose. And if men wish to see light, let them keep their fires lit, or provide in some other way.

First Hour. And how do you expect the poor dears to provide for themselves, Excellency? And to have to maintain their lamps or furnish sufficient candles to burn the whole day through will be an excessive expense. If the way of making that certain air [4] had already been invented—that air that is useful for burning, and for illuminating streets, rooms, shops, cellars, and whatnot, and all at small expense—I should say that the situation were not too serious. But the fact is that three centuries, more or less, will have to pass before men will discover that aid. And meanwhile they will exhaust their oil and wax and pitch and tallow and will have nothing left to burn.

The Sun. They will go hunting for lightning bugs and for those little worms that shine.

First Hour. And how will they provide against the cold? Without that aid which they were accustomed to have from Your Excellency, the fire of all the forests will not suffice to warm them. Besides, they will die of hunger, for Earth will no longer yield her fruits. And so at the end of a few years the seed of those poor animals will be lost. They will go for a while here and there on Earth groping, seeking the means to live and to warm themselves. Then finally, when everything has been consumed that can be swallowed, and when the last spark of fire has gone out, they all will die in the dark, frozen like pieces of rock crystal.

The Sun. What does that matter to me? Am I the human race's nursemaid? Or perhaps the cook who must ripen and prepare foods for it? And must I care if a certain small number of invisible little creatures millions of miles away from me do not see and cannot bear the cold without my light? And then, if I *must* serve as stove or hearth, so to speak, for this human family, it is reasonable that the family wishing to warm itself should come around the hearth—not that the hearth should go around the house. For this reason, if Earth has need of my presence, let her walk and make an effort to have it. For my part, I have need of nothing from Earth that I should seek her.

First Hour. Your Excellency means, if I understand correctly, that what he has done in the past now Earth may do.

The Sun. Yes. Now and forever more.

First Hour. Certainly, Your Excellency is very right in this matter. Besides, he can do with himself as he likes. But nevertheless, Excellency, deign to consider how many fine things will necessarily go to pot by Your wishing to establish this new order. The day will no longer have its beautiful golden cart with its fine horses which wash themselves in the sea. And aside from other particulars, we poor Hours shall no longer have a place in the sky; and from being celestial maidens, we shall become terrestrial maidens, unless, as I expect, we shall instead be dissolved into smoke. But about these matters let it be as You wish. The point will be to persuade Earth to go around, which is sure to be difficult because she is not used to it, and it is certain to appear strange to her to have to run forever and tire herself out when, until this hour, she has never budged from her place. And if Your Excellency now (as it seems) is beginning to lend a bit of his ear to laziness, I hear the Earth is not a whit more inclined today toward labor than she was at other times.

The Sun. Need, in this affair, will prick her and make her jump and run as much as is fitting. But, at any rate, here the quickest and surest way is to find a poet or philosopher who will persuade Earth to move, or who, when he cannot induce her in any other way, will make her go by force. In the final count, most of this affair is in the hands of the philoso-

phers and poets. Actually, they can do almost the whole business. It was the poets in the past (because I was younger and gave them ear) who, with those pretty songs, made me gladly do as for a sport or an honorable exercise that silly labor of running as if in desperation, great and fat as I am, around a speck of sand. But now that I am a mature age and have turned to philosophy, I seek utility in everything, and not the beautiful. Poets' sentiments, if they do not move my stomach, make me laugh. I wish to have good and substantial reason for anything I do, and I find no reason for putting the active life ahead of the idle and comfortable life. That former kind of life would not give you enough fruit to pay for its trouble, or even for only its thought, since there is no fruit in the world worth two cents. Therefore, I have decided to leave the toils and discomforts to others, and for my part to live at home quietly and without being busy. This mutation in me, as I have told you, is the effect of age. But it has also been caused by the philosophers, a people which in these times has begun to mount in power and everyday mounts higher. So, since I desire to make Earth move now, and to give herself to running around instead of me, from one point of view a poet would really be more appropriate than a philosopher. For the poets sometimes with one piece of nonsense, sometimes with another, give one to understand that the things of this world are valuable and weighty and very pleasing and beautiful, and they create a thousand merry hopes. They thus inspire in others the will to toil; while the philosophers disinspire. But, from another point of view, since the philosophers have begun to be on top, I doubt whether today a poet would be listened to by Earth any more than he would be listened to by me; or, if he were listened to, whether there would be any effect. Therefore it will be best to have recourse to a philosopher. Even though the philosophers ordinarily are not very active and are little inclined to move others to perform, still it may be that, in this extreme case, something will be done contrary to their custom—unless Earth will judge it more expedient for her to go to hell than to have to toil so much, in which judgment I should not say that she was wrong. Enough. We shall see what will happen. So you will do one thing: go there to Earth, or send one of your companions, one whom you will prefer. If she will find one of those philosophers standing outside his house in the coolness observing the sky and the stars (as she ought for reason of the novelty of this very long night), without further ado she will lift him up bodily, throw him on her back, and return and bring him here to me, when I shall see about arranging to have him do what is required. Have you understood?

First Hour. Excellency, yes. You will be served.

Scene II

Copernicus (on the terrace of his house, looking at the sky in the east through a small paper tube, because telescopes have not yet been invented).

This is a great thing. Either all the clocks are wrong or the sun ought to have arisen more than an hour ago. And here one does not see even a glimmer in the east, although the sky is as clear and polished as a mirror. All the stars are shining as if it were midnight. Now, go to the *Almagest* or to Sacrobosco and tell them to assign you the reason for this event. I have heard more than once of the night which Jupiter spent with Amphitryon's wife [5]. And I remember having read a short while ago in a recent book by a Spaniard [6] that the Peruvians tell about how in ancient times there was in their land a very long night—in fact an endless night; and how finally the sun came forth from a certain lake which they call Titicaca. But hitherto I have thought such tales to be mere gossip, and I have held the sun to be motionless as do all reasonable men. Now, when I perceive that reason and science, to speak properly, cannot explain things, I am determined to go to all the lakes and bogs that I can to see whether I might happen to fish out the sun. But what is this roar that I hear which sounds like a great bird's wings?

*Scene III**The Last Hour and Copernicus*

Last Hour. Copernicus, I am the Last Hour.

Copernicus. The last hour? Very well. Here one must resign oneself. Only, if it is possible, give me enough time to make my will and put my affairs in order before dying.

Last Hour. What do you mean, dying? I am not at all the last hour of your life.

Copernicus. Oh. Then who are you? The last hour of prayer from the breviary?

Last Hour. I can well believe that when you are at choir practice the last hour is dearer to you than the others.

Copernicus. But how do you know that? How do you know that I am a canon? How do you know me? For a moment ago you even called me by name.

Last Hour. I learned about you from certain persons below here, in the street. In short, I am the Last Hour of the day.

Copernicus. Ah, I have understood. The First Hour is sick. And for this reason the day is not yet seen.

Last Hour. Let me do the talking. There is to be no more day: neither today, nor tomorrow, nor henceforth—unless you provide it.

Copernicus. That would be good if the burden of making the day were to fall to my lot.

Last Hour. I shall tell you how. But first you must come with me without delay to the house of the Sun, my master. You will presently under-

stand the rest on the way, and part will be told you by His Excellency when we shall have arrived.

Copernicus. Everything is good; but the road, if I am not mistaken, must be quite long. And how can I bring sufficient supplies so that I shan't starve to death a few years before arrival? And besides, His Excellency's lands do not, I believe, produce the means to provide a single lunch for me.

Last Hour. Forget those doubts. You will not have to stay long at the Sun's house. And the trip will be made in an instant because I am a spirit, in case you don't know it.

Copernicus. But I am a body.

Last Hour. Indeed, indeed. You don't need to bother yourself with those discourses. You are not at all a metaphysical philosopher. Come here. Mount on my shoulders and leave the rest to me.

Copernicus. Forward: It's done. Let's see what this novelty will lead to.

Scene IV

Copernicus and the Sun

Copernicus. Most Illustrious Lord.

The Sun. Pardon, Copernicus, if I do not invite you to sit. For here chairs are not used. But we shall dispatch our business promptly. You have already learned its nature from my handmaiden. I, for my part, from what the girl reports to me about your ability, find that you are eminently suited for the effect which is sought.

Copernicus. Sir, I see many difficulties in this business.

The Sun. Difficulties ought not to frighten a man of your sort. Rather, they are said to increase courage in the courageous. But then, in the end, what are those difficulties?

Copernicus. Firstly, however great the power of philosophy may be, I am not certain that it is great enough to persuade Earth to give herself to running in exchange for sitting comfortably and to toiling in place of staying idle, especially in these times which are not at all heroic times.

The Sun. And if you cannot persuade her, you can force her.

Copernicus. Willingly, Most Illustrious Sir, if I were a Hercules, or even an Orlando, and not a canon of Warmja.

The Sun. What bearing has that on the case? Is there not a story of one of your ancient mathematicians who used to say that if he were given a place to stand outside the world, he could move Heaven and Earth? Now, you are not required to move Heaven and here you find yourself in a place outside Earth. So, supposing that you are not less than that ancient, you ought to be able to move her, whether she wants to or not.

Copernicus. My Lord, that could be done, but a lever would be necessary which would have to be so long that not only I but even Your Most Illustrious Lordship, however rich he may be, has not enough to pay for half the expense of the material to make it, and the labor. Another graver difficulty is this which I shall tell you [7] now. Rather, it is, as it were, an intricate knot of difficulties. Earth until today has held the first seat of the world, that is to say, the center. And (as you know), while she has stayed motionless without other business than to look around, all the other globes of the universe, no less the greatest than the smallest, the shining as well as the dark ones, have gone rolling around her above and below and to her sides continually, with a haste, a bustle, a fury to astonish one who thinks about it. And thus, since all things showed themselves to be busy in her service, it seemed as if the universe resembled a court in which Earth, as it were, sat on a throne and the other globes round about, after the manner of courtiers, guards, servants attended some to one task some to another. So, in truth, Earth has always believed herself to be empress of the world. And, in truth, affairs being such as they have been in the past, it cannot be said that she discoursed wrongly. Actually, I shall not deny that that conception of hers was well founded. What shall I tell you then about men? That reputed ourselves (as we ever shall repute ourselves) as more than first and more than chiefest among terrestrial creatures, each one of us, even though he were dressed in rags and didn't have a crust of stale bread to gnaw, has regarded himself as certainly being an emperor—not at all of Constantinople, of Germany, of half the Earth, as the Roman emperors used to be, but an emperor of the universe, an emperor of the sun, of the planets, of all the stars visible and invisible, and final cause of the stars, of the planets, of Your Most Illustrious Lordship, and of all things. But now, if we wish Earth to leave her place in the center, if we make her run, roll, toil continually, perform just that given amount, no more and no less, that hitherto the other globes have performed, finally if we make her become one of the number of the planets, this will entail that her terrestrial majesty and their human majesties will have to quit the throne and abandon the empire, still retaining, however, their rags and their miseries which are not a few.

The Sun. What, in short, do you wish to conclude from that discourse, my Don Nicholas? Do you perhaps have a conscientious scruple that the business involves the crime of lese majesty?

Copernicus. No, Most Illustrious Sir, because the codices, the digest, the books treating of public law, of the right to rule, of international law, of natural law, none of these mentions this crime of lese majesty, as far as I remember. But I wish to say in substance that our business will not be so simply material as it appears at first glance that it ought to be. Its effects will not belong to physics alone. It will upset the degrees of dignity

of things and the order of beings. It will interchange the ends of creatures. And therefore it will make a very great revolution also in metaphysics, actually in all that touches upon the speculative part of knowledge. And it will result from this that men, supposing that they will know how to discourse soundly or will want to do so, will find themselves to be wholly different stuff from what they have been hitherto, or have imagined themselves to be.

The Sun. My son, those things do not frighten me in the least, since I have as much respect for metaphysics as for physics and alchemy or necromancy, if you like. And men will be content with what they are; and if they don't like it, they will make a business of reasoning wrongly and arguing against the evidences of things, which they can very easily do; and in this way they will keep on regarding themselves as they wish: barons or dukes or emperors or anything else that they want, and by this they will be more consoled; and to me, with these judgments of theirs, they will give no displeasure whatever.

Copernicus. Forward: Let's leave men and Earth. Consider, Most Illustrious Sir, what reasonably may happen with the other planets. When they will see that Earth does everything that they do and that she has become one of them, they will no longer want to remain so smooth, simple, and undecorated, so deserted and sad as they have always been, and that Earth alone should have so many ornaments. But they too will want their rivers, their seas, their mountains, their vegetation, and among other things their animals and inhabitants, since they will see no reason why they should be less than Earth in any respect. And here is another very great revolution in the world. An infinity of families and new populations will be seen to arise on all sides like fungus.

The Sun. And you will let them arise and be as many as they know how to be. For my light and heat will suffice for all without any increase in expenditure for this. And the world will have the wherewithal to feed, dress, lodge, and treat them generously without running into debt.

Copernicus. May Your Illustrious Lordship think a little further and see still another mixup. The stars perceiving that you have put yourself to sitting and not at all on a stool but on a throne, and that you have round about you this fine court and this population of planets, will wish not only to sit and rest but to reign also. And for him who is to reign there must be subjects. Therefore, they will want to have their planets as you will have yours, each his own. It will be fitting that these new planets also be inhabited and decorated as Earth is. And here I shall not pause to speak to you of the poor human race which a short while ago became little more than nothing in respect to this world alone—shall not pause to speak of what it will be reduced to when so many thousands of other worlds will burst forth in such a way that there will not be the

least starlet of the Milky Way that does not have its own worlds. But considering your interest solely, I say that hitherto you have been, if not first in the universe, certainly second, namely, after Earth; and you have not had any equal, since the stars have not dared to compare themselves with you. But in this new state of the universe you will have as many equals as there will be stars with their worlds. So take care lest this mutation which we desire prejudice your dignity.

The Sun. Do you not remember what your Caesar said when, going through the Alps he chanced upon that tiny settlement of certain barbarians? He would have preferred (he said) to have been first in that tiny settlement than second at Rome. Similarly, I ought to prefer to be first in this our world than second in the universe. But it is not ambition that moves me to wish to change the present state of things. It is only love of quiet, or, to speak more properly, laziness. So that to have equals or not to have them, and to be in the first place or in the last place, do not mean much to me. Differently from Cicero, I have more regard for leisure than for dignity.

Copernicus. That leisure, Most Illustrious Sir, I, on my part, shall endeavor to do my best to obtain for you. But I doubt that even if I succeed in the attempt it will last for long. And first, I am almost certain that not many years will pass before you will be constrained to whirl incessantly like the pulley in a well, or a millstone, without changing place, however. Then, I have some suspicion that also, in the end, sooner or later, it will be fitting for you to take to running again. I don't say around Earth. But what does that matter to you? And perhaps that very spinning which you will do will serve as an argument for making you go again. Enough. Let that be as it will. In spite of every difficulty and every other consideration, if you persevere in your purpose, I shall endeavor to serve you. So that if I shall fail, may you think that I was unable, and not say that I lacked courage.

The Sun. Well said, my Copernicus. Try.

Copernicus. There would remain only one other difficulty.

The Sun. Speak up. What is it?

Copernicus. That I should not wish for reason of this business to be burnt alive after the manner of the Phoenix. For if this happens, I am sure that I shall not have the power to rise again from my ashes as that bird does, and that I shall never again see Your Lordship's face from that hour onward.

The Sun. Listen, Copernicus. You know that once upon a time, when you philosophers were still barely born (I speak of the time when poetry held the field), I was a prophet. I want you now to let me prophesy for the last time, and for the sake of the ancient virtue of mine to believe me. I say to you, then, that perhaps after you, to a few who will approve of what you will have done, it can be that some scorching [s] will occur,

or something similar. But you on behalf of this undertaking, from what I know, will suffer nothing. And if you wish to feel more secure, make this resolution: dedicate the book which you will write for this purpose to the Pope [9]. In this way, I promise you, you will not even have to lose your canonicate.

NOTES

1. Written in 1827 and published in the Edition Ranieri of 1845. This article is a translation by Rufus Suter, 3555 Chamoune Avenue, San Diego, California. [Translator's Note: The present translation is based on the text in *Giacomo Leopardi, Operette Morali. Rizzoli-Editore*, Milan, 1st Edition 1951. (Biblioteca Universale Rizzoli, 327-329), pp. 199-211. The following notes are taken from that text unless otherwise indicated.]
2. The first hour of daylight calculated in the ancient manner.
3. The star Venus, fair herald of the day.
4. Gas lighting, invented about ten years before this dialogue was written.
5. Alcmena, from whom Jupiter had Hercules as the result of a night which lasted three normal nights.
6. *La Chronica del Perú hecho por Pedro de Cieza*. This is, however, an anachronism since Cieza's book appeared seven years after Copernicus' death.
7. [Tr.'s note: Hitherto when Copernicus has addressed the sun he has used the most formal and respectful pronoun, *Ella*, which here is translated "You" with the capital "Y." From this point on, Copernicus addresses the Sun more familiarly with *vi* and *voi*, here translated plain "you." The Sun addresses Copernicus with *tu*.
8. Allusion to the martyrs of science, as, for instance, Giordano Bruno . . .
9. "Copernicus in fact dedicated the book to Pope Paul III" (Leopardi). The book is entitled *De revolutionibus orbium coelestium*.